

– if the current style of exploitative data analysis is to pervade.

According to a Gartner report, the volume of data generated by digital devices is expected to go through the stratosphere. Within the next five years, the Internet of Things devices will fly off the shelves and into our network terminals, with an estimated 30+ billion devices reported to be connected to the internet by 2020. This means that an average family will have 10 internet-connected devices in their home, if not more. The vegetable tray in your refrigerator may well be able to alert you when it's running low on fresh supplies and (who knows?) may even be able to automatically place an order for more in an online grocery store. This is no science fiction, it's fact-based reality expected to be true within just a few years.

Google's recent \$3.2 billion purchase of Nest, a maker of internet-connected thermostats and smoke detectors, is now starting to make a lot of sense, isn't it? Nest firmly believes in a "conscious home," and Google clearly can't wait to cash in on the profits it surely foresees in the offing and it will be trying hard to capture this market before anyone else. If your home is "conscious" and knows about you – not just you, but everyone else in there and sundry – just imagine what Google could

do with that data. And with all these possibilities, if user data isn't handled carefully and privacy is violated or infringed upon (as Google recently did through a series of Google+ gaffes), just imagine the backlash of users against an overarching system where rules are so dimly defined.

SOMETHING NEEDS TO GIVE TO RESTORE CONTROL AND TRUST. THEREFORE, GOVERNMENTS ARE NOW WORKING TO FORCE A CONVERSATION BETWEEN BUSINESSES AND THE PUBLIC, FROM A LEGAL POINT OF VIEW.

It's frightening to think that any unsuspecting object could one day possess the potential to spy on its owners and other people and tailor their experience of the internet, and maybe life at large through a bid for their eyeballs between cash-filled advertisers and marketers.

By all indications, the age of infancy as far as Big Data analytics and its applications are concerned is well and truly over, as consumers take notice and start worrying about the rapid increase in the collection and use of their per-

sonal information, and the potential for its abuse. Pew Research Center recently found that 50 per cent of Americans are concerned about their information on the Internet – up from 33 per cent in 2009. In addition, Pew's survey also reveals that a whopping 86 per cent have made efforts

toward hiding their online identity and not be tracked by entities without their explicit permission.

Ultimately, there's no running away from the fact that Big Data is here to stay and it's a necessary evil of our times. There's no running away from it, unless a return to Stone Age as an option is something that interests you. Undoubtedly, though, the positive use of big data in impacting social, cultural and political change in our lives outweigh its demerits by a long shot. And people are excited about this.

However, privacy issues related to big data analytics and the collection of consumer information have been hot topics in political circles of late. Covert NSA programs profiling and cataloguing civilian data, and governments around the world spying on their people have added to the atmosphere of mistrust that abounds in this sphere currently. However, something needs to give, and therefore governments are now working to force a conversation between businesses and the public, at least from a legal standpoint. If nothing else, at least it would be a start, as more work will follow, no doubt.

Until then, you, me, all of us who log in online – right from the instant we plug in our computers to a network terminal or connect to a Wi-Fi or cellular data signal on a smartphone or tablet – have to wake up to the reality that all of us are being tracked. We're all commodities and currencies to be traded on the internet, to run the web. Unless a better system arises, we're stuck with this, unfortunately. **E**



The future of data exposure and Internet is personalised experiences, all thanks to the advent of Big Data analytics that is increasingly dictating what you see on the Web